

MS Word Fundamentals — Detailed Lecture Notes

JKSSB Computer Awareness

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22.1 What MS Word is

MS Word (Microsoft Word) is a **word processor**: a program used to create, edit, format, store, and print text documents. It is one of the main applications in the **Microsoft Office** suite. A document written in Word is saved as a file, and the modern default file format uses the **.docx** extension. Word shows the document in a rectangular window that contains the document area together with several command areas around it.

Definition (Word processor). *An application that lets a user type text, change its appearance (formatting), arrange it on pages, and print it. MS Word is the common example.*

A word processor separates the *text* from its *appearance*. The same words can be displayed in many different fonts, sizes, colours, and layouts, because the formatting is stored alongside the text and can be changed at any time. This separation is the central idea of the whole lesson.

Part of the window	What it is
Document area	The white page where the text is typed and shown.
Ribbon	The strip of command tabs across the top of the window.
Quick Access Toolbar	The small row of always-visible buttons at the top-left.
Status bar	The strip at the bottom showing page, word count, and view buttons.

22.2 The Ribbon and its tabs

The **Ribbon** is the broad band of commands across the top of the Word window. It replaced the older style of drop-down menus and toolbars. The Ribbon is organised in three levels:

1. **Tabs** across the top: **Home**, **Insert**, **Design**, **Layout**, **References**, **Mailings**, **Review**, and **View**.
2. **Groups** inside each tab. For example, the Home tab contains the **Font**, **Paragraph**, and **Styles** groups.
3. **Commands** inside each group, such as the Bold button or the alignment buttons.

Some tabs are **contextual**. They are not shown all the time; they appear only when the right object is selected. When a table is selected, the **Table Tools** tabs appear; when a picture is selected, the **Picture Format** tab appears. The **File** tab is special: it does not show groups like the other tabs but opens **Backstage view**, which holds document-level actions such as New, Open, Save, Save As, Print, and Close.

Definition (Ribbon). *The command area of the Word window, organised into tabs, groups, and buttons, which replaced the older menu-and-toolbar layout.*

For exam purposes, the key point is that the **Home** tab carries the most-used formatting commands: the *Font* tools that change how characters look, and the *Paragraph* tools that change alignment, indentation, spacing, bullets, and numbering.

22.3 The Quick Access Toolbar

The **Quick Access Toolbar (QAT)** is the small row of buttons in the top-left corner of the window, just above the Ribbon. It is designed to hold the few commands a user needs most often, so they stay visible on every tab. By default it shows **Save**, **Undo**, and **Redo**. A user can **customise** it by adding or removing commands, and it can be moved to sit below the Ribbon if preferred.

Definition (Quick Access Toolbar). *A small, customisable toolbar at the top-left of the Word window that keeps frequently used commands (by default Save, Undo, Redo) visible on every tab.*

22.4 Creating, opening and saving documents

The **File** tab opens **Backstage view**, the part of Word where you work with the document as a whole rather than its contents. From here a user can create a new document, open an existing one, save, print, or close. The common keyboard shortcuts are worth memorising because direct-recall items ask for them.

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+N	Create a new blank document.
Ctrl+O	Open an existing document.
Ctrl+S	Save the current document.
Ctrl+P	Open the Print screen.

Save writes the current document back to its file. **Save As** writes a *copy* under a new name, in a new location, or in a different file format, leaving the original as it was. The default Word format is **.docx**; documents made with much older versions use the **.doc** extension.

Example 22.4.1. *A student types a letter and presses Ctrl+S, saving it as **letter.docx**. To keep the original and also produce a version for printing, the student uses Save As and saves a second file with a new name. The first file is unchanged.*

22.5 Entering and editing text

Text is typed at the **insertion point**, which is shown by a blinking cursor. **Word wrap** moves text automatically to the next line when the current line is full; pressing **Enter** starts a new **paragraph**. The **Backspace** key deletes the character to the left of the cursor, while the **Delete** key deletes the character to the right. **Ctrl+Z** undoes the last action and **Ctrl+Y** redoes it.

Text must be selected before it can be reformatted. A **word** is selected by double-clicking it, a **paragraph** by triple-clicking, and the **whole document** with **Ctrl+A**.

22.6 Font formatting

The **Font** group on the Home tab changes how individual characters look. It sets the **font face** (the typeface, such as Arial or Times New Roman) and the **font size**. It provides the style buttons **Bold** (Ctrl+B), **Italic** (Ctrl+I), and **Underline** (Ctrl+U), and it sets the **font colour** and **highlight**. It also applies effects such as subscript and superscript. Deeper options are available in the Font dialog box.

Definition (Font). *The typeface and its settings (face, size, style, colour) that determine how characters are displayed. Font formatting changes the appearance of characters, not their arrangement on the page.*

22.7 Paragraph alignment

Alignment decides where each line of a paragraph sits between the left and right margins.

Alignment	Shortcut	Effect
Left	Ctrl+L	Text lines up evenly on the left; ragged on the right. This is the default.
Centre	Ctrl+E	Each line is placed in the middle of the page.
Right	Ctrl+R	Text lines up evenly on the right.
Justify	Ctrl+J	Text is flush with both left and right margins.

Justify stretches the spaces between words so that both edges of the paragraph are even, which is why books and newspapers use it. **Centre** does not stretch anything; it simply moves each line to the middle.

22.8 Indentation

Indentation pushes paragraph lines inward, away from the margin. The **left indent** and **right indent** move the whole paragraph inward from the respective side. A **first-line indent** pushes only the first line inward, as in a typical book paragraph. A **hanging indent** pushes every line *except* the first inward, which is the standard layout for a references or bibliography list.

Definition (Indentation). *The inward offset of paragraph lines from the page margins. First-line indent affects only the first line; hanging indent affects every line except the first.*

Indentation must not be confused with **spacing**. Indentation shifts lines *horizontally*; spacing changes the *vertical* gaps.

22.9 Line and paragraph spacing

Line spacing sets the vertical gap between lines *inside* a paragraph; common settings are single, 1.5, and double. **Paragraph spacing** sets the gap *before* and *after* a paragraph. Both are controlled from the Paragraph group on the Home tab, or from the Paragraph dialog box. Using spacing is better than pressing Enter repeatedly to make gaps, because spacing stays correct when text is edited.

22.10 Bullets and numbering

Bullets mark list items with a symbol and are used when the order of the items does not matter. **Numbering** marks items with numbers or letters and is used when the order or sequence matters. **Multilevel lists** combine levels (for example 1, then 1.1, then 1.1.1) to build nested outlines. All three are applied from the **Paragraph** group on the Home tab.

Example 22.10.1. *A shopping list uses **bullets** because the order is irrelevant. A set of instructions to install software uses **numbering** because the steps must be followed in order.*

22.11 Tables

A **table** arranges information in **rows** and **columns**; each intersection of a row and a column is a **cell**. A table is inserted from **Insert** → **Table**. Cells can be **merged** into a single larger cell or **split** back into separate cells, and rows and columns can be inserted, deleted, and resized. When the table is selected, the **Table Tools** contextual tabs appear.

Definition (Table). *A grid of rows and columns used to arrange text in cells, inserted in Word from Insert → Table.*

22.12 Images and objects

An image is placed in the document from **Insert** → **Pictures**. **Handles** around the image let the user resize and rotate it. **Text wrapping** decides how the surrounding text flows around the image; options include In Line with Text, Square, Tight, and Behind Text. When the image is selected, the **Picture Format** contextual tab appears. Charts, shapes, and **SmartArt** are inserted from the same Insert tab.

Definition (Text wrapping). *The setting that controls how text flows around a picture or object. “In Line with Text” treats the image like a character; the other styles let text flow around the image.*

22.13 Headers and footers

A **header** is the area at the *top* of a page and a **footer** is the area at the *bottom*. Both repeat on every page of a section, which makes them ideal for a document title (in the header) and **page numbers** (in the footer). They are inserted from **Insert** → **Header** and **Insert** → **Footer**.

22.14 Page setup

Page setup is found on the **Layout** tab. It controls the overall page geometry: **margins** (the blank space between the text and the page edges), **orientation** (**Portrait**, which is tall, or **Landscape**, which is wide), and **page size** (for example A4 or Letter). The same tab sets **columns** and the page **breaks** described next.

22.15 Page break vs section break

A **Page Break** (Ctrl+Enter) forces the following content to start on a *new page*, but the page formatting stays the same. A **Section Break** starts a new **section** of the document, which can

carry its own page setup. The most important consequence for the exam is that only a **Section Break** allows a part of the document to have **different headers and footers**. Both are inserted from **Layout** → **Breaks**.

Example 22.15.1. *An item claims, “A Page Break can be used to give the first page a different header from the rest of the document.” This is wrong. A Page Break only moves content to a new page; to change the header or footer part way through the document, a **Section Break** is required. The wrong option has confused the two breaks (TRAP-13).*

22.16 Printing a document

Ctrl+P opens the **Print** screen in Backstage view. The **print preview** shows exactly how the pages will appear on paper. On this screen the user selects the **printer**, the number of **copies**, and which **pages** to print, then clicks **Print** to send the job to the printer. Checking the preview first catches wrong margins, stray blank pages, and cut-off text before paper is used.

22.17 Exam retrieval and common confusions

Five distinctions prevent most errors on this topic.

1. **Save** overwrites the current file; **Save As** stores a copy under a new name, location, or format.
2. **Ctrl+S** saves; **Ctrl+P** prints; **Ctrl+Enter** inserts a page break. Do not swap the shortcuts.
3. **Bullets** are for unordered lists; **numbering** is for ordered lists.
4. **Indentation** shifts lines horizontally; **spacing** changes vertical gaps between lines and paragraphs.
5. A **Page Break** does *not* change headers and footers; only a **Section Break** does (TRAP-13).

Example 22.17.1. *An item asks which shortcut opens the Print screen. Trace the File-level actions: New is Ctrl+N, Open is Ctrl+O, Save is Ctrl+S, and Print is Ctrl+P. The answer is **Ctrl+P**. If the stem instead asks for Undo, the answer is Ctrl+Z, and if it asks for a page break, the answer is Ctrl+Enter.*

Exercises

1. Name the main parts of the MS Word window.
2. What is the Quick Access Toolbar, and what does it show by default?
3. Distinguish Save from Save As.
4. List the four paragraph alignments with their shortcuts.
5. Explain the difference between a Page Break and a Section Break.

Solutions

1. The document area, the Ribbon (with its tabs and groups), the Quick Access Toolbar, and the status bar.
2. The Quick Access Toolbar is the small customisable row of buttons at the top-left of the window. By default it shows Save, Undo, and Redo, and it stays visible on every tab.
3. Save writes the current document back to its existing file. Save As writes a copy under a new name, location, or format and leaves the original file unchanged.
4. Left (Ctrl+L), Centre (Ctrl+E), Right (Ctrl+R), and Justify (Ctrl+J).
5. A Page Break (Ctrl+Enter) starts the following content on a new page while keeping the same formatting. A Section Break starts a new section that can have its own page setup — including different headers and footers. Only a Section Break can change headers and footers part way through a document.